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Confidential

Peking

24. June 1874.

No. 125

My Lord,

The French Minister, M. de Bourboulon, is going to Chefoo to escape the heat of Peking. It is almost certain, I regret to say, that he will not return here. He is a most agreeable colleague, and, considering the special nature of the interests confided to him as Representative of the Power protecting Romish Missions, considering also his own tendencies as a Frenchman, who is decidedly "clerical", he has always shewn himself disposed to behave

The Earl of Derby

reasonably

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reasonably by the Chinese. In his intercourse and correspondence with the Yamên he has treated it as he would treat the Foreign Department of any more civilized Government. That he has not succeeded better is not his fault, nor indeed wholly the fault of the Chinese, but the fault of the Missionary question, the difficulties of which appear to me daily more insoluble. Ricci-Lucci has greatly discouraged M. de Geofroy, and his

his apprehensions that, sooner or later, the anti-foreign feeling of the Chinese, especially against Missions, will discover itself in some fearful atrocity, such as the Massacre of 1870, are now inclining him to a policy which no Power, if so-minded, will be in a position to support.

I have mentioned that last year one of my Colleagues urged me to encourage the disposition manifested by Sogeeman to

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to annex Formosa. This was M. de Geofroy. Since this Japanese enterprise commenced, he has continually suggested the expediency of refraining from any measure that would embarrass the Japanese. As I have reported, he has laid something like an interdict upon M. Giquel's cooperation with the Chinese. He deplores bitterly the action taken by foreign Ministers in Japan, (as I conceive merely in satisfaction of their obligations to be neutral,) which is directed to the hindrance of

of foreign cooperation with the Japanese in acts of war. His argument is that China, if well humbled by Japan, would be found far more tractable by us, and would be less ready to offend. I admit this: but, obligations as a neutral apart, I am alarmed by Sir Harry Parkes, who complains as much of the pride and resolutiveness of Japan, as we of the same defects in China, that were the Japanese to obtain the upper hand in this quarrel, we

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we should meet for it in Japan.
This conviction I have accepted as entirely demolishing the conclusion I hazarded in my Despatch No. 50, of the 31st March. Sir H. Parkes contends, at the same time, that the Japanese are unequal to the enterprise in which they have engaged, and all that I have been enabled to learn confirms the correctness of this appreciation. If they were not to succeed, as I have before represented, Chinese success in a trial of strength would, on the other hand, cost us

much

much in the inflation of Chinese pride. So far, happily, the Chinese have sought to avoid public recognition of the character of the invasion of Formosa. Pray, happily, because if they talk the Japanese out of Formosa, the diplomatic success will not give them the same opportunity of self-glorification as a success in War. They will simply be able to announce to China that the Japanese have listened to argument-

There is one more reason against supporting Japan, to wit, that her

cause

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cause is essentially bad.

The Chinese, meanwhile, are in no little alarm - Always unwilling to strike they know further that the sympathy of foreigners is not - with them. We have, however, but little to hope from their fears unless they were to be seriously worsted which it is far from likely that - they will be.

The whole ground reviewed, I think that, morally and politically, it is our duty to favor rather the re-establishment of Chinese authority

over

over Formosa by negotiation than annexation of the island to Japan by force of arms.

I have the honor to be with the highest respect,

My Lord,

Your Lordships most obedient,

Humble servant,

Thomas Francis Wade -

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Peking. 24. June.

Hr. Wade

et. 125

confidential.

rec d. Sept. 7.

French Minister

leaving his policy.

27 Paris

The Queen

Mr. Disraeli

Circulate

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